

Cohesion & Coherence

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COHESION

- Cohesion is the glue that holds a piece of writing together. In other words, if a paper is cohesive, it sticks together from sentence to sentence and from paragraph to paragraph.
- Cohesive devices certainly include:
 - Reference
 - Substitution
 - Connectors
 - Ellipsis
 - Repetition
 - Synonymy

COHESION

- A paragraph or section of text is cohesive if the sentences are well structured, well linked together and there is no unnecessary repetition.

COHESION

Reference

- Anaphoric reference: referring backwards E.g. *I can see a bird. It is singing.* (*It* refers backwards to *bird*.)
- Cataphoric reference: referring forward. E.g. *When they arrived at the house, all the participants were very tired.* (*They* refers forward to *participants*).

Cohesion is...

- a formal feature of texts
- the glue that holds a piece of writing together
- fairly objectively verifiable
- achieved through cohesive devices:
 1. reference (*it, this, those cars, neither* etc.)
 2. ellipsis (i.e. avoiding repetition: Ø)
 3. substitution (i.e. avoiding repetition: *one(s), do*)
 4. lexical cohesion (e.g. repetition of lexis, synonyms, reformulation)
 5. conjunction (*in addition, for instance* etc.)

Cohesive Devices

(co-he-sive de-vi-ces)

Definition:

Cohesive devices are words and phrases that link sentences and paragraphs, ensuring clarity and flow in writing.

Examples:

- However
- Therefore
- In conclusion
- Thus
- Consequently
- In addition
- On the other hand

Types:

- Reference
- Substitution
- Ellipsis
- Conjunction
- Lexical Cohesion
- Reiteration
- Collocation



Coherence in Paragraphs



Poor coherence

The industry has many advantages. It can draw on a great deal of research. It can also export products to key trading partners. It has significant growth potential in the medium to long term. Workers within this industry need training. It is important to keep staff up-to-date with software used in this industry.

Strong coherence

*The industry has many advantages. It can draw on a great deal of research, **particularly in terms of** strategies used for entering new markets. **While** there is significant growth potential in the medium to long term, **it is clear that** workers within this sector need training. **Therefore,** it is important to keep staff up-to-date with software used in this **industry**.*



Coherence



Cohesion

For Cohesion in Sentence Beginnings . . . Put the OLD FIRST

- Begin your sentences with information familiar to your readers,
- Don't begin a sentence with a bit of new information,
- Don't begin a sentence with a bit of technical information,
- Use your openings to refer back to previous material or gently introduce a new topic.

For Cohesion in Sentence Endings . . . Put the NEW LAST

- End your sentences with new information your readers cannot anticipate
- Don't end a sentence with old information
- Put the new, technical, and difficult information at the end of the sentence
- Use transitions to convey the connections between the ideas in your sentences

Here's an example passage:

As a reminder, please promptly return the lecture notes you borrowed. Slide the notes under my door if I am not there. I may become agitated if you are late, much like my Uncle Chester after several eggnogs on Christmas Eve. Most Christmases I liked to stay up and open my stockings after midnight. Staying up late was exciting and would be repeated a week later at New Year's. So would Uncle Chester's disgraceful behavior.

Here are four main components of cohesion:

- Relevance
- Order
- Linking words
- Repetition of key words

1. RELEVANCE

- A simple way to build cohesion or flow between sentences is to look at the meaning of a sentence and compare it to the point of the next sentence.
- If the two sentences are not closely related, you will lose the readers' attention, because they will have to guess where you are going.
- If the two sentences are identical, you are not adding any new information to your work, and the reader will be annoyed.

Example – Too different: relevance not clear

Antigone's motivation is family duty, even if it means death. *She must rebel which will cause an uproar - the consequences don't matter to her. This would also explain why she rejects Ismene's support later in the play.* They both have different motivations - Ismene has nothing left to lose and wants to go out with a glorious bang.

- In this paragraph, two sentences are far too separate.
- The first two sentences talk about Antigone's motivations and how far they will drive her.
- The focus is then redirected to Ismene, and the paragraph focus is not clear. It lacks cohesion.
- When a sentence relates the Ismene information back to Antigone, we have cohesion:

Antigone's motivation is family duty, even if it means death. She wants to rebel which will cause an uproar - the consequences don't matter to her. *In contrast, her sister, Ismene, has completely different motivations for her actions and wants glory, which explains why Antigone rejects her support later in the play.*

Example – Too similar

Aristophanes exaggerates Socrates' intelligence in a humorous way. *Aristophanes portrays Socrates' intelligence as a tool of humor.* He makes Socrates use his intelligence to make a mockery of people. *Aristophanes makes Socrates appear very brash in the use of his intelligence.*

- The author conveys only two points with these four sentences – that Aristophanes uses Socrates' intelligence as a joke, and that he did so by having Socrates mock people.
- Cutting away the unnecessary repetitions strengthens cohesion:

Aristophanes exaggerates Socrates' intelligence in a humorous way. The playwright makes Socrates use his intelligence to make a mockery of people, being very brash in the process.

2. ORDER

- Writers should always ask themselves “Is this sentence relevant to the idea of this paragraph?”
- Every paragraph should have a main idea (typically stated in a topic sentence).
- To maintain cohesion, all sentences within a paragraph should relate to this main idea.

Common ways to order sentences:

- Chronological
- Cause and Effect
- Clarification (first sentence is broad, general statement, and the following sentences explain it with details)
- Compare/Contrast

Example – Chronology is unclear

Then there was another meeting with Satan, who said if Job's body was tested Job would sin against God. *The three friends Eliphaz of Teman, Zophar of Naamah, and Bildad the Shuah came to try and console Job.* The three saw then that Job was stricken with disease and his suffering was very great.

➤ Chronological order and time signals improve cohesiveness:

There was another meeting with Satan, who said if Job's body was tested Job would then sin against God. *When Job was later stricken with disease and suffering greatly, his three friends, Eliphaz of Teman, Zophar of Naamah and Bildad the Shuah, tried to console him.*

Cohesive Words and Phrases

1. Additive words

Also, and, as well as, at the same time as, besides, equally important, further, furthermore, in addition, likewise, moreover, too, not only... but also.

2. Amplification words

As, for example, for instance, in fact, specifically, such as, that is, to illustrate

3. Repetitive words

Again, in other words, that is, to repeat

4. Contrast words

But, conversely, despite, even though, however, in contrast, notwithstanding, on the one hand / on the other hand, still, although, though, whereas, yet, nevertheless, on the contrary, in spite of this

5. Cause and effect words

Accordingly, as a result, because, consequently, for this reason, since, as, so, then, therefore, thus

6. Qualifying words

Although, if, even, therefore, unless

7. Example

For example, for instance

8. Emphasizing words

Above all, more/most importantly

9. Reason words

For this reason, owing to this, therefore

10. Order words

Afterwards, at the same time, before, firstly/secondly, formerly, lastly, finally, later, meanwhile, next, now, presently, today/yesterday/last week/next year, subsequently, then, until, ultimately, while, historically, in the end, eventually

11. Explanation

In other words, that is to say

12. Attitude

Naturally, of course, certainly, strangely enough, oddly enough, luckily, fortunately, unfortunately, admittedly, undoubtedly

13. Summary

Finally, in conclusion, in short, to sum up

COHERENCE

- A text is coherence whe it makes sense.

It makes sense when:

- We can understand what the text is about.
- We can translate it.
- We can paraphrase it.
- We can summarize it.
- We can explain the meaning to someone else.

COHERENCE AND COHESION

Coherence is the logical unity and organization of ideas in a text.

Lack of coherence means that points within one paragraph are unrelated (or paragraphs within one text are unrelated).

Cohesion is the connection of sentences through linguistic means, which allow to achieve a smooth text flow effect. Cohesive elements include conjunctions, reference words, substitution and lexical devices such as repetition of words, collocations, and lexical groups.

What we need to know is that the text should not sound like a list of bullet points (lack of cohesion), and ideas should be placed in a logical order (coherence).

COHERENCE

DEFINITION

Coherence refers to the logical and consistent interrelation of ideas. In a coherent argument, the content flows smoothly, making it easier for readers or listeners to understand and follow. Coherence is achieved through the organized structure of ideas, clear connections between concepts, and the use of transitional words and phrases.

EXAMPLES

- **Transitional Phrases:** Use transitional words and phrases like "however," "in addition," "on the other hand," and "as a result" to guide readers through your argument.
- **Consistent Tense:** Stick to one tense (past, present, future) throughout your writing to avoid confusing readers.

COHERENCE

- Words are correctly arranged so that ideas correctly convey the intended meaning.

EXAMPLE

UNCLEAR: Being an excellent lawyer, I am sure you can help us.

CLEAR:

As you are an excellent lawyer, I am sure you can help us.

Coherence

- Another example...

The Austrian composer Mozart was a musical genius. He has got a swimming pool. It actually tingles on your skin to tell you it's working. Water would then come out of fountains such as the one shown here. And that is why dogs still chase rabbits.

Is it coherent?

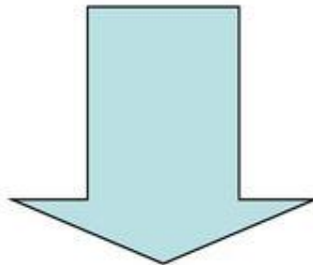


A TEXT TO BE COHERENT
MUST REFER TO THE SAME TOPIC

Coherence

- Example of an incoherent text

He worked hard but earned little money and died very poor at the age of 35. Two years later his father took him to play at concerts in the great cities of Europe



Does it make sense?

Thank
you

The image features the words "Thank you" rendered in a playful, 3D block letter font. The letters are a pale yellow color with a thick blue outline. They are arranged in two lines: "Thank" on top and "you" below it. Each letter casts a soft, reddish-pink shadow onto the light pink background. Scattered around the text are several small, five-pointed stars in various colors: light blue, yellow, and purple. Each star also has a small, darker red shadow beneath it, giving the entire scene a sense of depth and whimsy.